salary as second lieutenant was around four hundred rupees and barely sufficed to keep one's head above water. Yet we managed to behave like 'sahibs' of the Raj period, wearing white sharkskin jackets and black bow-ties with Wellington shoes and spurs for informal mess functions. We used to go to the gymkhana at the cantonment, and made a few Anglo-Indian and Goan friends. We would organize dance parties once in a while, mostly on Saturdays. Everyone pooled in for the food. We were most sought after as we took care of the drinks, and rum was the favourite, particularly the XXX Hercules rum from the army canteen! At one of these 'dos' I met an attractive Bengali girl. We became friends. We enjoyed dancing together, particularly the foxtrot, the quickstep or the cha-cha-cha. I had become proficient in ballroom dancing at the NDA. She wanted to learn from me and I agreed to teach her. However, this was when I learnt that she was married, and she became off-limits as far as I was concerned. Shortly thereafter we moved to Naga Hills.

As young officers, after clearing our monthly mess bills and other dues, we were left with very little out of our meagre salary; and by the twentieth day we would be almost bankrupt! What would we have done without our regimental banias? They readily helped to bail out the 'rank and file' financially whenever we were broke. Of course, they would take their pound of flesh and never forgot to charge us a hefty interest. But loans were not a problem, and unlike banks the bania never took a holiday or stuck to fixed working hours. It was 24x7 the year round for this tribe.

This petty trader, contractor and private banker all rolled into one has existed as an institution in the Indian Army since ages. We must give credit to the British for this unique invention. We have known of two or even three generations that have served with certain battalions and regiments. The battalion in which I was commissioned forty-seven years ago, has seen three generations of the first unit bania, Har Narayan Aggrawal, who began his trade along with the raising of our battalion. Now his son and grandson run the show. A century or two ago, this breed was among the important camp followers moving behind the conquering armies.